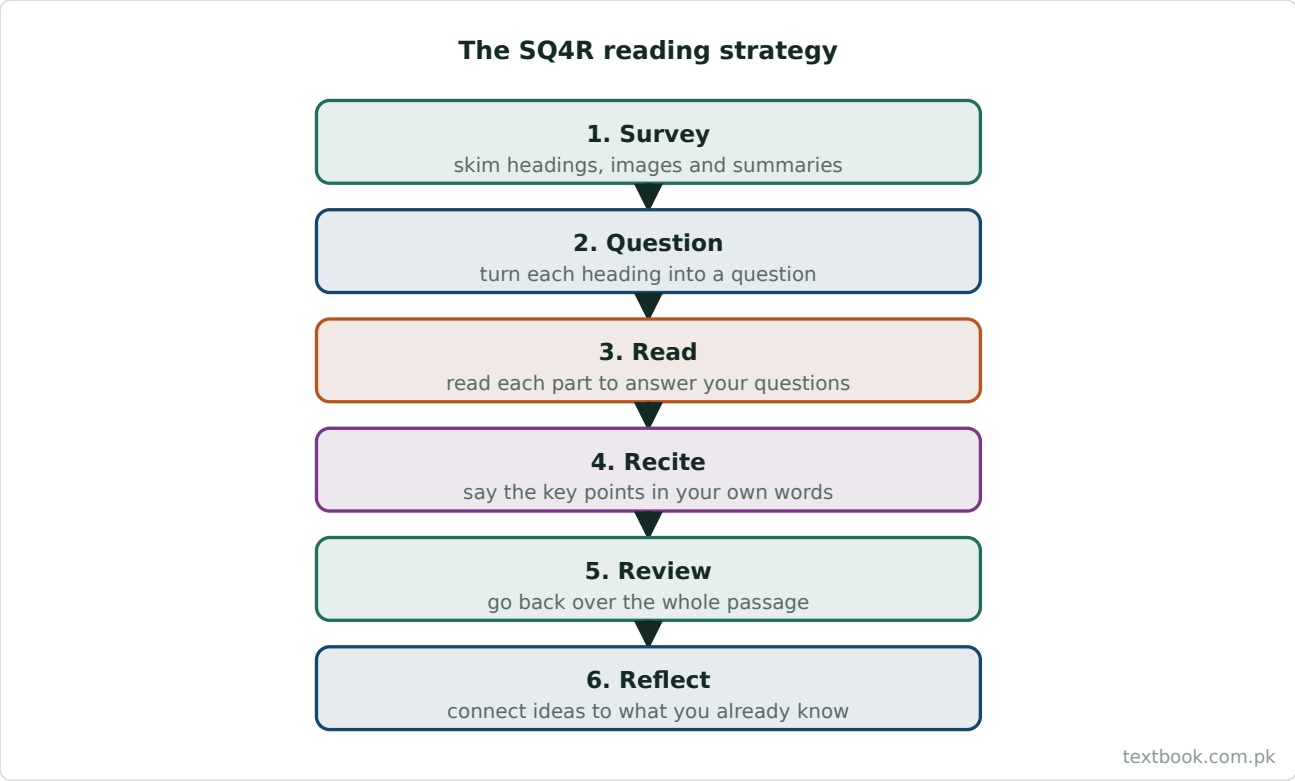
Draft - expert review pending

This unit is complete and passes the platform’s automated checks, but no reviewer has read it yet. Treat its sources and claims with care.

Topic 2.2 - Strategies for reading and listening

A real classroom situation



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Miss Fatima teaches Class 8 English in a government school in Peshawar. She gives her pupils a three-page textbook chapter and tells them to read it. Some pupils read every word from start to finish and remember little. Others look at the headings first and do better. This topic is about why some reading strategies work better than others.

Explanation

Good readers do not read every text the same way. They adjust their strategy to their purpose. This topic covers the main reading strategies and the listening strategies that complement them.

Reading strategies

Reading strategies matched to purpose

Strategy	When to use	What it gives you
Skimming	to get a general idea quickly before close reading	a fast overview of the main point
Scanning	to find a specific fact, name or detail	the exact information you need, fast
SQ4R	to understand and remember a full text in depth	deep, lasting comprehension
Critical reading	to judge bias, evidence and logic	an evaluative, questioning grasp of the text

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The figure above maps the main reading strategies and when to use each one.

Skimming is reading quickly to get the main idea of a text. You read the title, the headings, the first and last paragraphs, and any bold or italic text. Skimming answers the question: "What is this text about, and do I need to read it in more detail?" It is the right strategy when you are deciding whether a text is relevant.

Scanning is reading quickly to find specific information. You look for a name, a date, a number or a keyword. Scanning answers the question: "Does this text contain the information I need?" It is the right strategy when you know what you are looking for.

SQ4R is a structured strategy for reading a text in depth. The figure above maps the steps: **S**urvey (skim the text to get an overview), **Q**uestion (turn each heading into a question), **R**ead (read to answer the question), **R**ecite (summarise the answer in your own words), **R**eview (go back and check your understanding), **R**eflect (connect the content to what you already know). SQ4R is the right strategy when you need to understand and remember a text.

Critical reading is reading to evaluate a text, not just understand it. You ask: What is the writer's purpose? What assumptions are being made? What evidence is provided? What is left out? Critical reading is the right strategy when you need to assess the quality or reliability of a text.

Active listening

Active listening is listening with the intention to understand, not just to hear. It is the aural equivalent of critical reading. The guide lists several barriers to active listening and strategies for overcoming them.

Overcoming listening barriers. Common barriers include distractions (noise, movement, daydreaming), bias (stopping listening when you disagree), and language difficulty (losing the thread when the speaker uses unfamiliar vocabulary). Strategies include: sitting where you can hear clearly, focusing on the speaker rather than your own thoughts, and noting key words rather than trying to understand every word.

Focused listening is listening for a specific purpose. If you are listening for the main idea, you focus on the introduction and conclusion. If you are listening for detail, you focus on specific facts and figures. If you are listening for tone, you focus on the speaker's voice and word choice.

Note-taking is recording what you hear in a way that helps you remember and review. The figure above maps common note-taking formats: linear notes (headings and bullet points), mind maps (branches radiating from a central idea), and Cornell notes (a divided page with cues, notes and a summary). Different formats suit different purposes.

Common misconception. "Listening is a passive skill." It is not. Active listening requires focus, strategy and engagement, just like critical reading.

Activity: Apply SQ4R to a text

Work alone. Take a three-page English text (a textbook chapter, a newspaper feature, or an academic article). Apply the six steps of SQ4R: survey, question, read, recite, review, reflect. Allow 30 minutes. Then compare your notes with a partner and discuss which steps were most useful.

Check your understanding

1. Name the four reading strategies and state when each is most useful. *(Remember)*
2. A pupil says, "I read every word but I cannot remember anything." Using this topic's account, explain what is going wrong and what strategy would help. *(Analyze)*
3. Explain the difference between skimming and scanning, and give one example of each. *(Understand)*
4. A friend says, "I just listen and hope I will remember." Using this topic's account, explain why this approach is unreliable and propose three specific strategies. *(Apply)*
5. Describe the Cornell note-taking format and explain when it is most useful. *(Remember)*

Summary

Reading strategies (skimming, scanning, SQ4R, critical reading) are tools that good readers choose according to their purpose. Active listening requires focus, strategy and engagement. Note-taking formats (linear, mind map, Cornell) help you record and review what you hear.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can name the four reading strategies and state when each is most useful.
- [ ] I can explain the difference between skimming and scanning.

- [ ] I can describe the six steps of SQ4R.
- [ ] I can identify common listening barriers and strategies for overcoming them.
- [ ] I can describe at least two note-taking formats and when to use each.

Try this at your practicum school

Observe one English lesson in which pupils are asked to read a text. Note the reading strategies the teacher explicitly teaches (if any) and the strategies the pupils actually use. Write half a page on the match or mismatch and what you would do differently.

Summative task

Write 350 to 400 words on the following.

> A pupil in your practicum school says, "I read the chapter three times but I still cannot answer the questions." Using this topic's account of reading strategies, explain what the pupil is doing wrong, propose two specific strategies the pupil could use instead, and justify each choice by reference to the purpose of the reading.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Analysis of what is going wrong (Analyze)	Explains that reading without a strategy is inefficient, not just that the pupil needs to try harder
Proposal of two strategies (Apply)	Proposes two specific strategies from the topic (e.g. SQ4R, critical reading)
Justification by purpose (Analyze)	**Explains why each strategy fits the purpose of the reading, not just names the strategy**

Criterion	What a strong response does
Register and clarity	Writes for a colleague, defines any technical term used, stays within the word count

Further reading

- Johns, J., & Lenski, S. *Improving Reading: Strategies, Resources, and Common Core Connections.* (guide recommended)
- Kintsch, W. *Comprehension: A Paradigm for Cognition.* (guide recommended)

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback